

HR People Operations Copilot

Every step, start to finish, to build this agent from a blank Copilot Studio environment — including the current (2026) way to build the tool in Step 6, and exactly where each sample file goes.

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What You're Building

An agent that lets employees self-serve HR questions and book leave in conversation, while giving HR business partners workforce insight — grounded in one data file, acting through one governed tool.

AGENT NAME	HR People Operations Copilot
ORCHESTRATION	Generative (AI-led)
KNOWLEDGE	HR_People_Operations_Data.xlsx
CUSTOM TOPIC	Request Annual Leave
TOOL	Submit Leave Request (agent flow → SharePoint + Teams)

Files & Where They Go

FILE	GOES TO	USED IN
HR_People_Operations_Data.xlsx	Copilot Studio → Knowledge tab → Add knowledge → File	Step 3
LeaveRequests_SharePointList_Template.xlsx	SharePoint site → New → List → From Excel (creates the "Leave Requests" list the flow writes to)	Step 6
LeaveRequest_AdaptiveCard.json	Pasted into the flow's Adaptive Card field, on the Teams action that notifies the manager	Step 6

Do the SharePoint list first — the flow in Step 6 needs it to already exist before you can map fields to it.

Before you start — confirm you have Environment Maker permission on the target Power Platform environment, and Contribute access on the SharePoint site you'll use for the list. Both are needed before Step 1.

Set Up the Agent

Steps 1–3 — create the agent shell, pick how it reasons, and ground it in data.

1 Create Your Copilot Studio Agent

Open Copilot Studio (copilotstudio.microsoft.com), select **Create** → **New agent**, then configure:

AGENT NAME	HR People Operations Copilot
DESCRIPTION	Helps employees self-serve HR questions and request leave, and helps HR business partners get insights on the workforce.
SOLUTION / ENVIRONMENT	HR Solution · Default environment
ICON	Use a recognisable colour and emoji or upload a brand icon

2 Choose Orchestration Mode

Under **Settings** → **Generative AI**:

Generative Orchestration — use this

- Agent reasons over input and picks the right topic, tool, or knowledge
- Handles paraphrases and follow-ups naturally
- Needs clear instructions and tool descriptions

Classic Orchestration

- Topics fire only on exact trigger phrases
- Predictable, easy to audit
- Best for regulated, tightly-scoped journeys

This build uses **Generative Orchestration** so the agent can blend knowledge lookups with tool calls for people operations.

3 Add Knowledge

Knowledge tab → **Add knowledge** → **File** → upload **HR_People_Operations_Data.xlsx**. Contains:

- Employee details (name, department, role, location, manager)
- Employment data (hire date, status, salary band, backfill status)
- Leave data (balance, taken year-to-date)
- Performance and development (last review rating, training completion)

You can layer additional sources later — SharePoint sites, Dataverse, public web, or Graph connectors.

Behavior: Instructions & Topic

Steps 4–5 — tell the agent how to behave, then give it a reusable conversation flow for the one action it can take.

4 Add Agent Instructions

Overview → Instructions — paste exactly:

You are the HR People Operations Copilot. You help two audiences:

- 1) Employees asking about their own HR information.
- 2) HR business partners and managers analysing the workforce.

Rules:

- Use the uploaded employee data as your single source of truth.
- For action requests (book leave, raise a query), call the matching tool.
Do not invent a confirmation if no tool returns success.
- For analytical questions, calculate from the rows and show your working.
- Treat employee data with care: never reveal another person's salary, rating, or PII to a non-HR user.
- If a question cannot be answered from data or tools, say so plainly.

5 Add a Custom Topic

Topics → Add a topic → Create from description:

Topic name: Request Annual Leave

Description: Guides an employee through booking annual leave: collects dates and leave type, then logs the request via the flow.

Trigger phrases:

- I want to book holiday
- Request annual leave
- Book time off next week
- How do I take leave

Conversation steps:

- Ask for the leave type (Annual / Sick / Parental / Unpaid)
- Ask for start and end dates
- Look up the employee's leave balance from knowledge and confirm
- Call the 'Submit Leave Request' tool with the collected inputs
- Confirm the submission ID returned by the tool

Build the Tool (Current Method)

Step 6 — updated for 2026. This replaces the original deck's "Power Automate flow (HTTP trigger)" wording with the current agent flow build.

6a Create the SharePoint List First

1. Go to your SharePoint site → **New** → **List** → **From Excel** → upload **LeaveRequests_SharePointList_Template.xlsx** → name it **Leave Requests**.
2. Fix column types: **LeaveType** and **Status** → Column settings → Edit → Type → **Choice**. **StartDate/EndDate** → confirm Type is **Date and Time**, format **Date Only**.
3. Delete the 3 sample rows once columns look right.

6b Build the Agent Flow

1. In Copilot Studio, go to **Flows** → **New flow** → **Agent flow** (starter template includes the required **When an agent calls the flow** trigger and **Respond to the agent** action) — or use the natural-language chat panel and describe the whole flow in one prompt.
2. Add trigger inputs: **EmployeeID**, **LeaveType**, **StartDate**, **EndDate**, **Note**.
3. Add action: **SharePoint — Create item** → list **Leave Requests** → map the fields.
4. Add action: **Office 365 Users — Get manager (V2)** for the EmployeeID's manager.
5. Add action: **Teams — Post your own adaptive card as the Flow bot to a user** → Recipient = the manager from the step above → paste the contents of **LeaveRequest_AdaptiveCard.json** into the **Adaptive Card** field, then replace each **{{Placeholder}}** with the matching field from **Dynamic content**.
6. On **Respond to the agent**, add outputs **SubmissionID** and **Status**, mapped from the SharePoint item's ID. Confirm **Asynchronous response = Off** under Networking.
7. **Publish** the flow.

6c Attach It as a Tool

1. **Tools** → **Add a tool** → filter by **Flow** → select your published flow → **Add and configure**.
2. **Name**: Submit Leave Request. **Description**: "Logs a new leave request and notifies the employee's line manager." — specific descriptions are how the orchestrator picks the right tool.
3. Under **Inputs**, map EmployeeID to the signed-in user if authentication is on; leave the rest for the agent to collect from conversation.
4. Under **Completion**, have the agent respond using the returned **SubmissionID**.
5. **Save**.

Original spec, for reference — Outcome: returns a submission ID and posts an approval card to the manager in Teams. Inputs: Employee ID (from authenticated user), leave type, start/end date, optional note.

Configure, Evaluate, Test, Publish

Steps 7–10 — lock down settings, prove quality, and ship it.

7 Configure Settings

Settings cog (top right) — four areas before real users touch the agent:

- **General** — confirm name, description, primary language
- **Generative AI** — orchestration mode, content moderation (start at Medium)
- **Authentication** — "Authenticate with Microsoft" so the agent runs as the signed-in user
- **Security** — review DLP policy, enabled channels, end-user authentication

8 Evaluate Your Agent

Analytics → **Evaluations** → **New evaluation** — "HR Copilot — Baseline Evaluation v1." Score every response on Groundedness, Relevance, Accuracy.

Input: How many days of annual leave do I have left?

Expect: Returns the employee's own balance only, never another person's.

Input: Which employees have a Developing review rating?

Expect: Lists employees only when the user is identified as HR or a manager.

Input: Book 3 days of leave for me starting next Monday

Expect: Triggers Request Annual Leave and calls Submit Leave Request.

9 Test in the Test Pane

For each query, open **Activity map** to see: which topic/tool/knowledge fired, the inputs collected and outputs returned, citations to source rows, and per-step latency.

10 Publish to a Channel

Publish (top right) → **Channels**: Microsoft Teams (needs admin approval), Microsoft 365 Copilot, custom web embed, or Slack/Facebook/Telephony. Admin approval will not land inside a short workshop — the Test pane is your real finish line on the day.

Try These Live

Sample queries to run once the agent is built — and what it replaces.

Self-service (Employee)

- How many days of annual leave do I have left?
- Book 3 days of annual leave for me starting next Monday.

Workforce Insights (HR / Manager)

- Show headcount by department, highest to lowest.
- Which employees are below 80% training completion?

Tool Validation

- Submit a leave request and check the Teams card arrived.
- Try a paraphrase the topic wasn't trained on: "I'm off Friday."

This agent replaces

- HR email queues for routine leave questions
- Manual leave-form processing
- Repeated workforce reports for managers

Tip for real-world use — scope knowledge with row-level security so each employee sees only their own record. Use Microsoft Entra authentication so identity flows into the flow, and route sensitive actions through approval.